

highways development scheme.

"We rolled out a financing arrangement from a cess pool created by a levy of Re 1 per litre on petrol and diesel, ensured clearances to land hurdles, imported machinery to get the best technology for making roads. We even put in incentives to expedite the NHDP by giving 1 per cent of the contract value every month as bonus up to a maximum of six months for early completion," says Khanduri.

Not surprisingly, funds for the first phase, amounting to around Rs 32,000 crore, were fast-tracked. Also by early 2004, the Government had invited bids for seven contracts in another set of projects called "Bharat Jodo Pariyojana", renamed Phase III by the UPA. By the time the NDA remitted office in May 2004, about 2,800 km of the GQ and 630 km of the North-South-East-West (NSEW) corridor was in place, according to Khanduri.

But progress under the UPA has been particularly tardy. The GQ and the NSEW, which were expected to be onstream by 2006 and 2008 respectively, as per the UPA's revised deadlines, are behind schedule. The

Highs and Lows of the NHDP

Phases	2000	2004	2008	Total (Dec. '08)
Phase I GQ	5,846 km (approved in 2000)	2,801 km (40 months)	2,903 km (55 months)	5,704 km
Phase II NSEW Corridor	7,300 km (approved in 2003)	633 km (5 months)	2,450 km (55 months)	3,083 km
Phase III Upgradation and Four Laning	12,109 km (approved in 2005-07)	NDA out, UPA in	613 km	613 km
Phase IV Widening Highways	20,000 km (approved in 2005)	Yet to kick off		
Phase V Six Laning	6,500 km (approved in 2006)		63 km (26 months)	63 km
Phase VI Expressway Links	1,000 km (approved in 2006)		Feasibility report being prepared	

most damning aspect is that the UPA has failed to finish any of the highway projects in phases III, IV, V and VI, started in its own tenure. The rate of completion of targets in all phases has slipped from 73 per cent in 2005-06 to 56 per cent in 2007-08.

Matters have worsened in the last few months. According to the Ministry of Road Transport and High-

ways (MORTH), the NHAI has not awarded a single project between July and December last year, holding up 60 projects worth Rs 70,000 crore. But going by fresh official estimates, the cost of these projects may have gone up by 20-40 per cent. If this is factored in, the UPA's dilly-dallying may have held up projects worth Rs 84,000-Rs 98,000 crore. So why are the min-

